

KEEPING UP

appearances

REGENCY AND VICTORIAN BRITAIN

Succeeding socially in Georgian Britain (1714–1837) relied on the skilful negotiation of many conventions governing behavior and relationships. This was especially important for women, whose reputation was usually their ticket to marriage and its associated financial security. To attract a husband, middle- and upper-class women were expected to be fashionable in both dress and lifestyle, to boast impeccable manners, and to have an intricate knowledge of etiquette. Connections were fostered through “morning” visits to other homes, following a strict protocol. In London, for example, a woman could visit her social equals or inferiors, but she had to wait for higher-ranked women to call on her. Good form was so prized that British

high society was dubbed “the Ton”, from the French word *bon ton* for good manners or style. Such conventions played a key role in the works of British writer Jane Austen, whose novels provided an often damning social commentary on the upper class.

In the Regency period of the early 19th century, women changed clothes around six times a day for different occasions: breakfast, morning visits, afternoon promenades, evenings at home, dinners out, and balls. They were expected to be well read on the politics and prevailing tastes of the time, but any sign of ostentatiousness was frowned

► Fan flirtation

Decorative fans were significant in the elaborate rituals of flirtation at European balls. They allowed women to communicate their feelings toward suitors in a socially acceptable manner despite restrictive social customs.

